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How to Bring Back Dropouts

Instead of new schools, existing ones must be made to function well

There are two statistics I find most alarming. First, nearly 50 per cent of Indian children don't complete eight years of school, while 30 per cent don't complete five years. Two, only 11 per cent of the youth access higher education. There is a fashionable belief these days which seems to suggest that the expansion of higher education will offset the abject failure of the school system but it is not so. In a country that prides itself on the demographic dividend, what do we do with the wastage of such mammoth proportions? There are two problems in Indian schools. They are not inclusive enough and they do not encourage

Pradesh Government appoint one lakh teachers? These should be hired by individual schools to breed a sense of commitment and responsibility, while they continue to be paid by the state. It will also end the transfer industry and bring the community and school closer.

► Every state should have an independent regulator of all schools—government and private—which will safeguard standards. There should be inspection teams which will spend a week in every school and distribute reports to all stakeholders. This will ensure accountability in the system.

► Schools routinely accept non-attendance. It should not be the case. Parents are as accountable as teachers if a child does not come to school. Most often children, who do not come to school, are not engaged in any other productive activity at home or elsewhere. There should be zero tolerance for such negligence.

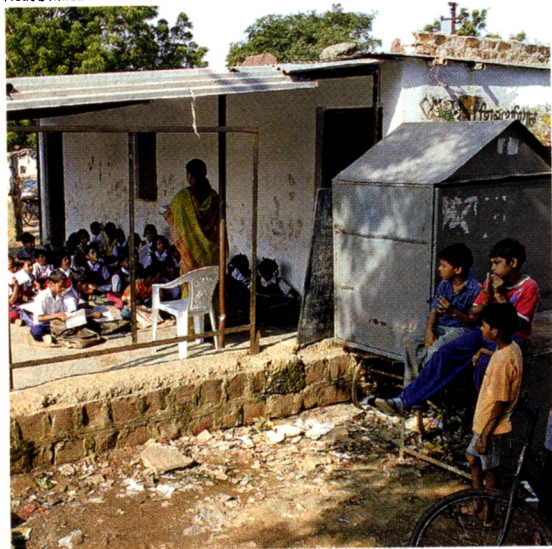
► The corporate sector, which is clamouring to invest in education, could spend its money better by starting free schools of its own, running them for 15 years and then turning them over to the community rather than installing computers in non-functioning government schools or starting alternative schools. The cohort entering primary schools is going to fall, so the next 15 years are crucial for society. We need bold ventures in school education. In a primary school, if you nurture a good teacher, the returns will be enormous.

Only if these things are done will more children come to college. Right now the base is very narrow so the problem is not that children don't have enough colleges. It is that children don't have enough good schools. This attending, not learning, is a national disaster compounded by the fact that we have no national programme for young people in their adolescence. All ideas suggested for this have come a cropper with the government tossing it among its internal departments. We don't have enough imagination for this. We repeat the Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan year after year, but do not formulate new initiatives to improve school functioning. Merely multiplying clones of failed institutions will not take the country anywhere. We can't afford to run out of new ideas. We need independent policy think tanks that come up with imaginative ideas and present alternative perspectives. ■

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PANKAJ TIWARI



INDIAN SCHOOLS DON'T ENCOURAGE ENHANCED LEARNING

enhanced learning. By inclusive I don't mean just the physical presence of children in classrooms but also the silent exclusion of children who attend school for eight years but barely learn anything. Not only are they excluded from higher education but also from society as a whole. How do we resolve this problem?

► By ensuring government schools, which comprise around 90 per cent of all primary schools in India, work better. This will happen if teachers are appointed to individual schools and not the system. For instance, why should the Uttar